WWJD

By Will Weaver

LIKE JESUS, I am surrounded by sin. Every morning on my way to school I walk past rough boys with shaved heads and girls with pierced faces. They stand inches off the high school property line and smoke cigarettes. When I appear, they whoop and swear and throw their trash at me. Every morning I am their amusement. Their victim.

I could easily avoid my tormentors by taking a different path from my aunt's house. But I try to live by one rule: WWJD. What would Jesus do? And the answer is clear. Jesus never took the easy way out. He never avoided the sinners, the lost, the lonely, the hurting. Rather, He went among them.

INTRODUCTION

Being a transfer student is difficult enough, but Suzanne also carries other burdens into her new high school. When counseling and drug therapy don't help, Suzanne's religious beliefs give her strength. However, her major tormentor, Eddie Halvorsen, won't give up. WWJD by Will Weaver.

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Today I carry a black plastic garbage bag. My antagonists do not see me immediately-two of them are wrestling in the snow. The rest are laughing and egging them on. I tighten my long orange scarf around my throat, and quietly I ease behind them. I begin to pick up their trash.

"Hey look, it's Weird Suzy!" Weird Suzy, Weird Suzy! they all begin to chant. Sticks and stones. Their name-calling does not bother me. After all, my real name is Suzanne. I am a sixteen-year-old sophomore at River Forks High School in central Wisconsin, and the year is 2001. But I don't feel like this is my school, Wisconsin my state, or these times my times.

This morning a can of Mountain Dew clatters at my feet. Yellow spray splashes my clothes, spatters my face.

"Good hit, Eddie!" someone calls. I look up to my main tormentor, Eddie Halvorsen.

"Hey, pick up my can, Weird Suzy," Eddie says. I bend down to get it. I place it carefully in my

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garbage bag. "This too, freak," Eddie says. From between his thumb and middle finger he flips his cigarette directly at me. I'm not quick enough to avoid it, but would not have anyway. The cigarette stings my cheek like a bee. Sparks fly as the butt falls at my feet. I touch my cheek; gray ash comes off on my finger tip. I draw my ashy finger slowly across my forehead, then bend to pick up the dead butt.

The parking lot monitor, an off-duty security guard, trots across the street. He comes first to me. "Are you all right, miss?" he says. "You could have put her eye out," the guard says, catching Eddie by the arm.

Eddie shrugs. "I was just getting rid of my butt. Can't help it if she got in the way."

"If this were on school property, you'd be gone-for good," the guard says.

"But it ain't. It's public property. I got my rights, now shove off and stop bothering me."

Then the first hour bell rings. My tormenters

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look at one another, then swear loudly. Burping and cursing, they throw down their trash, then trudge onto school property. I wait for them to leave. My cheek stings a little but I keep working with my garbage bag.

"Suzanne-come along now," a voice says. I look up. It's the assistant principal, Ms. Kaufman. She takes my garbage bag in one hand and my arm in the other. She reminds me of my real mother, who is in prison. I have not told anyone in River Forks about this. She has leaned in to stare at my cheek. "You'd better drop by the nurse's office and get your face looked at. There's a little blister on your cheek."

"Eddie," I say. I touch the burned spot.

"The parking lot monitor told me. Would you like to fill out a harassment report?"

WWJD? "No," I say.

"I really encourage you to do so. Eddie is out of control these days. You would be helping him."

"A change of heart must come from the inside," I murmur.

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Ms. Jones, the nurse, puts ointment on my face. She tries to wipe clean the ash mark but I lean away. "I consider it a religious symbol," I say. "Like the mark Catholics wear on Ash Wednesday," I add.

"Suzanne, today is Monday." Her eyes flicker down the rest of me. At my hair. At my clothes, which I get from the Salvation Army. At my sandals, which I made myself in shop class from tire rubber, leather straps, and buckles. At my long orange scarf, which I wear everywhere. Her eyes return to my hair. 'Are you keeping up your hygiene, Suzanne?" she says. "Good personal hygiene is important- particularly for girls." She smiles and winks. "Let me give you some samples of shampoo and deodorant," she says.

Next I go to the counselor's office. "Who's next? Why, it's Suzanne!" Mr. Klephorn calls heartily. "Come on in!" A hearty greeting is requisite for all counselors. That and positive body language. He glances at a memo on his desk. "I understand that you had an encounter with Eddie Halvorsen this

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morning."

"Nothing serious. I have no complaint against Eddie. I think he's going through tough times right now. Jesus is trying to speak to him."

Mr. Klephorn purses his lips. "He burned your cheek. I can see the mark from here."

"And I've forgiven him."

"Suzanne, we've talked about this ... forgiveness thing.I know you're a very religious person," he continues. "You read the Bible every day."

"Yes. Though mainly in the New Testament. I find the Old Testament too centered upon retribution, revenge. Jesus believed not in punishment but in forgiveness. In turning the other cheek."

"Yes, of course, Suzanne," he says quickly. "But my point, one we've talked about before, is that this is the twenty-first century. These are different times than when Jesus lived. And we must live in them. We must inhabit our *own* times, so to speak." He clears his throat. "While Jesus provided

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us wonderful lessons, it is, may I say, perhaps unrealistic to try and live His example every minute of our day."

There is silence as I think about that. Then I say, "But isn't that why we go to church? Why we read the Bible? To live more like Jesus? There are no limits to forgiveness," I say.

My day goes all right. What I'm looking forward to is my last class of the day, woodworking. I've always liked to make things, plus I don't mind being surrounded by boys (I'm the only girl). It is among boys that I can do the most good. At 2:00 P.M. I go to woodworking. Eddie Halvorsen is there, along with the other "woodies." as they call themselves. He glares at me.

I begin work on my wooden swan. The neck of my black walnut swan curves up gracefully. I've been working on her all term, and she's really getting beautiful. Even Mr. Patterson complimented me on her. He let me do a project different from the boys, most of whom are making gun cabinets. But I love my

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swan. When I work on her, she reminds me that there is hope for Eddie. For all of us.

After school, on my way home, it is snowing. I walk with my head down and my scarf wrapped around my face. It never snowed in California. Suddenly someone blocks the sidewalk. "Weird Suzy!" Eddie says.

I stop. Blink. "Hello, Eddie," I say. For a moment he scares me. But I remember that Jesus must have been afraid many times. Suddenly Eddie whoops and snakes out his arm; he grabs my orange scarf and strips it from my neck.

I blink against the falling snow and look at him. WWJD? I set down my book bag, take off my coat, hold it out to him. "Take my coat too," I say. He stops, stares. Then he grabs my coat, throws it in the snow.

"My hat too," I say. I take off my beret, hand it to him. He throws it in the snow. He laughs. I peel off my sweater-I have on only a T-shirt underneath and it is suddenly very chilly-and I hand

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it to him. After a moment's hesitation, he takes it. He swallows as he stares at me. I am shivering in the February air. Suddenly he flings my sweater in my face so hard I stumble back. "What in hell is the matter with you?" he says. His voice cracks. When I look up again, he is disappearing in the snow.

The next morning I walk to school the usual way. Eddie's gang spots me, as usual. But this morning Eddie will not look at me. He stands with his back to me, his hands jammed in his pockets. I can feel his anger. His hard heart. Light snow is falling again and has whitened his cap and shoulders. For a moment he looks like a pillar of salt.

In shop class Eddie's dark eyes follow me as I go to my locker, unlock it, carefully take out my swan lamp. I go to my station and begin work. Working on my swan makes me forget everything, even my mother.

"What the hell's that supposed to be, anyway?" Eddie says in my ear. I turn. He grabs at my swan. I jerk it away from him and cradle it in my

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arms. Eddie laughs. I feel my face flush. I shouldn't have jerked my swan away from Eddie. It's not something Jesus would have done. Slowly I hold it out so that he can see it-but not touch it.

"It's a swan," I say.

"Looks like a damned crow to me," Eddie says.

"It's not finished," I answer. "Like all of us." He stares at me. I see the hate in his eyes.

"You should have stayed in California, you freak." After he leaves I turn back to my swan but my hands are shaky. For one brief moment I understand what Jesus felt like when He knew that He was the One. The Chosen One. "Take this cup," I murmur to my swan. "Choose someone else to help Eddie." But she is silent.

I do not see Eddie after school, which today is all right by me. I take a walk down by the river. I often come down here to pray. Today I pray for my mother that she will not forget me-and especially for Eddie Halvorsen.

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Near school the next morning Eddie calls out to me. "Hey, Suzy! How's it going?" I stare. His voice is almost cheerful. None of his friends throw anything at me. They are all smiling. I do not quite understand this, but not everything Jesus does is understandable. I smile a little, nod and pass by.

In shop class I go straight to my locker. I can't wait to get started. But my padlock, broken, falls into my hands. I stare at it, then at my little metal door. Its hinges are bent. Slowly I pull open the door. My swan falls out in pieces. She clatters to the floor like a spilled puzzle that cannot ever be put right. I can't help myself: I drop to my knees, clutch the pieces, and begin to wail. I hear myself calling for my mother.

I leave school late. I have been in the nurse's office. Finally she lets me go home. I head down by the river, when I am aware of footsteps.

"Hey, Weird Suzy." Eddie says. "What happened to your crow?"

I stop. "It was a swan," I blurt. "A black

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swan." I hunch under my scarf and keep walking.

"So where you going now, Weird Suzy?" he says.

"Down by the river," I say.

"Gonna drown yourself?" Eddie says. He laughs with an odd, high-pitched sound. "Maybe today's the day," he whispers, close behind me now. "If not now, when, Weird Suzy?" Eddie says.

To get away, I head down the bank, past a "Danger -Thin Ice!" sign. "That's right. Good girl!" Eddie calls. He follows me down the bank. I step onto the ice.

I walk out several yards, toward the middle of the river where there is a dark, steaming, open patch. I think of Jesus when He walked on water. It was all a matter of faith. I move a couple of steps closer to the black water. Then I turn and face Eddie, who remains on the white shore. "Are you coming?" I say. "Don't be afraid."

He laughs but there is something thin and reedy and strangled in his throat. "You can do it," I

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say. I beckon him forward. "Come out to where I am," I say. He stops. "It's all a matter of not being afraid," I say. He takes several more steps-and suddenly there is a sound under his feet like foil ripping. Eddie's arms flap, like a bird taking off, as his legs and trunk disappear through the ice. He screams. I wonder if my black swan screamed when its head was cut off. Suddenly, Eddie is hanging on to the ice by his elbows. Most of his body is underwater.

"Help! Help me!" A car stops on the parkway; the driver quickly lifts a cell phone to his face. "Save me," Eddie screams. "Someone! Suzy! Please! Save me!"

I watch him. I think of my swan. My butchered black swan. I think, What would Jesus do? Possibly I could save Eddie, though he seems to have a grip on the ice. I have my long orange scarf. It would be enough to throw to him. It would be something for him to hold on to until help arrives. But I understand that not even Jesus could save

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everyone. I sit down on the ice just out of Eddie's reach. I must think about what to do. After all, I am only human.

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AWARD HISTORY

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